

To begin with, open any image you want to beautify with the HDR effect. For this tutorial, I am using a dull wallpaper of a pyramid that's been languishing in my collection of wallpapers.

Step 1 Open the image in the GIMP and duplicate the background layer.

Step 2 Select the newly created layer and desaturate the layer using *Colors→Desaturate*, with 'Average' as the desaturation mode.

Step 3 With the same desaturated layer selected, invert the colour from *Colors→Invert*. Inverting the colour gives a more striking appearance.

Step 4 It's time to add more luminosity to the image. Head to *Filters→Artistic→Soft Glow*. With default settings, apply the effect.

Once you have applied the effect, the image turns bright and shining. This does hurt the eyes and is too bright for our HDR effect. So we will tone the effect down by reducing opacity and changing layer modes.



Note: The effect for the top-most layer will be more pronounced. Thus, in order to show/introduce an effect, move the desired layer to the top position or change the layer mode of the top-most layer.

Step 5 Once you have applied the effect, set the layer mode to Softlight and reduce the opacity to 50.

Step 6 Duplicate the same layer and set the opacity to 75.

The lighting is still too bright and there is no sign of dynamic darkness in the image. Since HDR is about both darkness and luminosity, we need to cast a spell of some dark magic as well.

Step 7 Duplicate the bottom most/source layer and drag it above the rest.

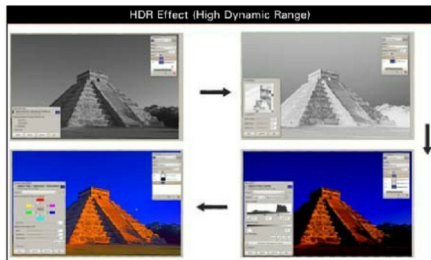


Figure 1: HDR effect in action

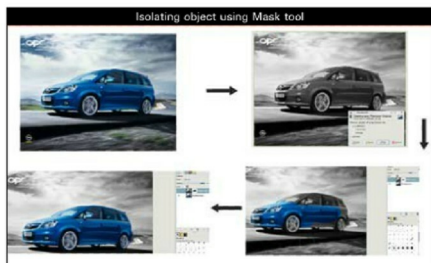


Figure 2: Isolating using mask

Step 8 Navigate to *Color→Levels* and set the first output level to 100 (as shown in Figure 1). This turns the image to severe black, which is not our cup of tea either. So, we will tone this down as well.

Step 9 Set the layer mode of the top-most layer to 'Darken Only' and reduce the opacity closer to 45.

We are almost done. Just right click on the layer and select 'Merge all visible layers'. With default settings select 'OK'. Now, here is when the Dodge and Burn plug-in comes into play. We will be needing it to add more depth and make the image stand out from the background.

Step 10 Head to *Script-Fu→Enhance→Dodge and Burn*. Change the thin amount to 10-15 depending on personal taste and apply it.

Notice that the effect adds two new layers to the image. We don't have to bother about them. Just select the base image and its time to add the final ingredient.

Step 11 With the background layer selected, navigate to *Color→Hue Saturation*. Increase the saturation way up to 50-60, depending on the brightness you are looking for.

That's it! We have created a cool effect, making the image more